

Antarctica

With an area of 5.4 million sq miles (14 million sq km), Antarctica is the fifth-largest continent, and the coldest. Almost all of its land is covered in an ice sheet that is 15,400 ft (4,700 m) thick in places. It is the southernmost continent, with the South Pole at its center. With rainfall of only 8 in (20 cm) per year, Antarctica is also classified as a desert.



RESEARCH BASES

Antarctica belongs to no single nation and has no permanent human residents. But up to 4,000 people (mostly scientists) live there at research bases during the summer months, when there is sunlight for 24 hours a day and ships can get through the sea ice.

SURVIVING THE COLD

Various species of penguins and seals live on Antarctica, feeding on fish and other marine life from the surrounding ocean. These creatures are thickly insulated with a layer of fat in order to survive in the icy waters.



▲ **ANTARCTIC ICE SHEET**
Antarctica's gigantic ice sheet shrinks in summer but expands in winter (marked by a small dotted line above) as temperatures fall. The parts of an ice sheet that stretch out over the sea are known as ice shelves.